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Volume XXXIII Number 34: For the week August 19-25, 2008, released on August 18

● Editorial Office: Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001. Phones: 23315801-4; Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi

● Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301; Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines), (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 407080; e-mail: ircare@indiatoday.com, Mumbai: 022-24444423-6, Fax: 24444358 ● Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi ● Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 ● Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Panel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 ● Hamilton House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 ● 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Inio In; Fax: 28472178; Cable: Livmedia Chennai ● 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore ● 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22826398; Fax: 22827254; Cable: Livmedia, Kolkata ● 6-3-8857/8, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 ● 39/1045, Karakkatt Road, Kochi-682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059 ● 2X, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchsati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293

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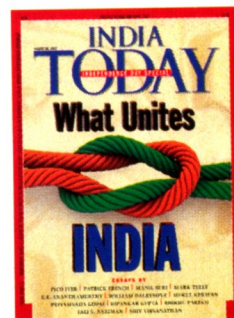
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What makes a nation great? Yes, its people. But also the institutions they leave behind. The greatest survive those that founded them. And nowhere is it as true than in the 61 institutions INDIA TODAY has chosen in its 61st Independence Day special issue. They reflect the vision of men and women who could see into the future. Jawaharlal Nehru, who despite his manifest faults, could reflect as beautifully on the past as he could plan for the future. Meghnad Saha, whose alert mind could move from the complexities of calendar reform to the intricacies of the cyclotron. Homi Bhabha who turned a chance meeting with J.R.D. Tata into a proposal to the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust which set the ball rolling for the nation's atomic energy programme. Vikram Sarabhai, a man who could switch as easily from being the spirit behind the IIM, Ahmedabad, to being the pioneer behind the Indian Space Research Organisation. Men like Rabindranath Tagore, who set up the free-spirited Santiniketan; Sir Jamsetji Tata who was prompted by a meeting with Swami Vivekananda to set up the Indian Institute of Science; or even Sir William Jones, an Englishman of Oriental inclinations, who parlayed a love for all things Indian into the Asiatic Society in Kolkata.

It is all too easy to keep the past where it belongs. But as India moves into a world where the World Trade Organisation matters as much as a change in the US administration, it has to keep its institutions alive to the possibilities of change. Some younger institutions such as IITs have adapted marvellously, inextricably linked with the success of its diaspora, while others have weathered age and politics less well. Many of our institutions need to be scrapped as they have become cesspools of corruption or just sinecures for retired bureaucrats or politicians, and have long outlived their original purpose.

Despite that, for anyone who loves the nation's anarchy as much as its achievements, there is a lot to learn. Associate Editor Sandeep Unnithan spent time at the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration in Mussoorie to understand the system which produces our bureaucrats; Senior Editor Amarnath K. Menon reported on how the Defence Research and Development Laboratory in Hyderabad turned failure into success by steering the integrated missile programme while fashion designer Ritu Beri remembered her days at the National Institute of Fashion Technology as she belonged to the first batch when a designer was considered no better than a *darzi*. Filmmaker Saeed Akhtar Mirza recalled his time at the Film and Television Institute of India. As he says, he entered and exited on a strike but learnt to become an individual in the three years in between. In this special issue, we celebrate our finest institutions. These are our nation's building blocks and we neglect them at our peril.



Our August 2007 cover

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)